

Rachit Dubey

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BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH

A. Personal Statement

My research sits at the intersection of cognitive science, policy, and AI. I develop formal models of human motivation such as curiosity, adaptation, and persistence, and use them to diagnose where cognition succeeds and where it fails, particularly in high-stakes domains such as climate change and AI adoption. Methodologically, I combine large-scale behavioral experiments (typically $N > 1,000$ on Prolific), computational modeling, and causal experimental designs. A core goal of my lab is producing findings that are both mechanistically precise and directly actionable for policy. My work has been covered by the *New York Times*, *Atlantic*, *Guardian*, *Bloomberg*, *Washington Post*, *BBC*, *Wired*, and *Vox*.

B. Positions, Scientific Appointments, and Honors

Positions

Assistant Professor, Department of Communication, UCLA	Jul 2025–
Postdoctoral Research Fellow, Computer Science, Princeton University	2024–2025
Postdoctoral Research Fellow, MIT Sloan School of Management	2023–2024

Education

Ph.D., Computer Science, Princeton University (Advisor: Tom Griffiths)	2018–2023
M.S., Education, University of California, Berkeley	2015–2018
B.Eng., Computer Science, Nanyang Technological University, Singapore	2008–2012

Selected Honors and Awards

UC Early Career Faculty Research Excellence Award	2026
Honorable mention, Laude Institute Moonshot program	2026
Osher Fellow, San Francisco Exploratorium	2026
Rising Star Award, Association for Psychological Science	2026
Science Magazine Protostar	2025
Grand Prize Winner, NOMIS & Science Young Explorer Award	2025
UCLA Nominee, Frontiers Planet Prize (Frontiers Research Foundation)	2025
Society for the Neuroscience of Creativity Dissertation Award	2024
Princeton Energy and Climate Scholars Fellowship	2021
Top Reviewer (top 8.5%), NeurIPS 2020; Top Reviewer (top 33%), ICML 2020	2020

Selected Grants

AI-Assisted Democratic Deliberation to Improve California Transport Policies.	2026
UC Institute of Transportation Studies (PI). USD 100,000	
Countering Climate Normalization. University of California, Early Career Award (PI). USD 50,000	2026
Reimagining Democratic Deliberation. Laude Institute (Co-PI). USD 100,000	2026
The Habermas Machine. Cooperative AI Foundation (Co-PI). USD 376,510	2025–2026

C. Selected Publications

See [Google Scholar](#) for full publication list.

1. Liu, G., Christian, B., Dumbalska, T., Bakker, M., & **Dubey, R.** (2026). AI assistance reduces persistence and hurts independent performance. *Conference on Language Modeling*.

2. **Dubey, R.**, Ho, M., Mehta, H., & Griffiths, T.L. (2026). Aha! moments correspond to metacognitive prediction errors. *Cognition*.
3. **Dubey, R.** (2025). The normalization of (almost) everything. *Science*, 390(6773), 585-585.
4. Liu, G., Snell, J., Griffiths, T.L., & **Dubey, R.** (2025). Binary climate data visuals amplify perceived impact of climate change. *Nature Human Behavior*, 1-10.
5. Yu, D., Thompson, B. D., & **Dubey, R.** (2025). Leveraging AI to advance psychological research for climate policy. *Current Opinion in Behavioral Sciences*, 65,101547.
6. **Dubey, R.**, Hardy, M., Griffiths, T.L., & Bhui R. (2024). AI-generated visuals of car-free US cities help improve support for sustainable policies. *Nature Sustainability*, 7(4), 399-403.
7. Dulberg, Z., **Dubey, R.**, Berwian, I., & Cohen, J. (2023). Having “multiple selves” helps learning agents explore and adapt in complex changing worlds. *PNAS*, 120(28), e2221180120.
8. **Dubey, R.**, Griffiths, T.L., & Dayan, P. (2022). The pursuit of happiness: A reinforcement learning perspective on habituation and comparisons. *PLOS Computational Biology*, 18(8), e1010316.
9. **Dubey, R.**, Griffiths, T.L., & Lombrozo, T. (2022). If it’s important, then I’m curious: Increasing perceived usefulness stimulates curiosity. *Cognition*, 226, 105193.
10. **Dubey, R.** & Griffiths, T.L. (2020). Reconciling novelty and complexity via a rational analysis of curiosity. *Psychological Review*, 127(3), 455.
11. **Dubey, R.** & Griffiths, T.L. (2020). Understanding exploration in humans and machines by formalizing the function of curiosity. *Current Opinion in Behavioral Sciences*, 35, 118-124.
12. **Dubey, R.**, Agrawal, P., Pathak, D., Griffiths, T. L., & Efros, A. A. (2018). Investigating human priors for playing video games. In *35th International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)*.
13. **Dubey, R.**, Peterson, J., Khosla, A., Yang, M. H., & Ghanem, B. (2015). What makes an object memorable?. In *Proceedings of the IEEE International Conference on Computer Vision (ICCV)*.

D. Additional Information

Selected Media Coverage

- **Press related to work on AI and persistence:** [New York Times](#), [Wired](#), [The Atlantic](#), [Futurism](#).
- **Press related to work on normalization:** [Science Adviser](#), [CBC Quirks and Quarks](#), [The Hindu](#).
- **Press related to work on “boiling frog” effect:** [Guardian](#), [Grist](#), [Gizmodo](#), [New Scientist](#).
- **Press related to work on AI and sustainable policies:** [Bloomberg](#), [Washington Post](#), [MIT Sloan Ideas Made to Matter](#).
- **Press related to work on curiosity:** [BBC](#), [British Psychological Society](#), [MIT Technology Review](#).

Selected Service

- Reviewer: *Nature Human Behavior*, *Nature Communications*, *Psychological Review*, *Cognition*, *Nature Sustainability*, NeurIPS, ICML, ICLR
- Organizer: “Combating the climate crisis with cognitive science” workshop, CogSci 2021